



*Teaching
Genealogists AI™*
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Census Records for Puerto Rican Genealogy

Module 9 — Handling Parish Access Limitations

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Learning Objectives

By the end of this module, you will:

- Understand why parish registers matter for research before civil registration (pre-1885)

- Know the current access restrictions affecting the Diocese of Mayagüez and what they mean in practice
 - Distinguish between registers already digitized at FamilySearch and registers held only at the parish
 - Build a GPS-compliant alternative source strategy when parish records are unavailable
 - Document restricted access and negative searches as part of a reasonably exhaustive search
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Section 1 — Why Parish Registers Matter

Before civil registration began on June 17, 1885, the Catholic Church was the principal record keeper of vital events in Puerto Rico. Parish registers of baptism (*actas de bautismo*), marriage (*actas de matrimonio*), and burial (*actas de defunción* or *entierros*) are often the only surviving name-level records of individuals born, married, or buried before 1885.

For most Puerto Rican family lines, the chain of evidence runs backward like this: federal census (1910–1950) leads to civil registration (1885–2001), and civil registration leads to parish registers (pre-1885). When the final link in that chain is inaccessible, research into earlier generations does not stop, but it does change shape. This module explains how.

Section 2 — The Mayagüez Diocese Restriction

As of 2025, the Diocese of Mayagüez, which covers Mayagüez, Rincón, Añasco, and surrounding municipalities in western Puerto Rico, restricts researcher access to its parish registers and prohibits new digitization. The diocese has cited prior abuse of records and limited institutional resources as reasons for the policy.

What this means in practice:

- You cannot visit these parishes and examine original registers as a researcher
- No new digitization or indexing projects are being authorized within the diocese
- Requests for individual sacramental certificates (for example, a baptismal certificate for a direct ancestor) are handled at each parish's discretion and are separate from research access

What this does not mean:

- It does not erase what was digitized before the restriction. FamilySearch microfilmed and digitized many Puerto Rican parish registers decades ago, and those images remain available (see Section 3).
- It does not affect civil registration, census records, or any other record class covered in this course.
- It does not apply island-wide. Parishes in other dioceses follow their own access policies.

A note on research etiquette: The restriction is the diocese's decision to make, and it deserves respect. Do not pressure parish staff, misrepresent the purpose of a request, or encourage others to do so. The credibility of the research community depends on how individual researchers behave at the archive door.

Section 3 — First Step: Check What Is Already Digitized

Before treating a parish register as inaccessible, confirm whether it was captured before the restriction. The FamilySearch collection **Puerto Rico, Catholic Church Records, 1645–2021** contains digitized registers from many municipalities:

<https://www.familysearch.org/en/search/collection/1807092>

Coverage varies by parish and by date range. A parish may have digitized baptisms through one year and nothing after, or marriages but not burials. To check coverage for your municipio:

1. Open the collection and browse the image groups by municipality and parish
2. Note the record types (baptisms, marriages, burials) and the year ranges available
3. Record what is covered and what is missing in your research log, with dates

If the register you need was digitized, the access restriction does not affect you for that search. If it was not, the alternative strategy in Section 4 applies.

Section 4 — The Alternative Source Strategy

When a parish register is genuinely unavailable, the goal is to assemble the same facts from other record classes. No single substitute carries the full content of a baptismal entry, but a correlation of sources frequently does.

Civil Registration (1885 forward)

The strongest substitute. Although civil registration begins in 1885, its records reach backward in content. A death record from 1895 for a person born in 1820 names the deceased, their age, often their parents, and surviving family. A marriage record names both spouses' parents, reaching one generation back from the marriage date.

https://www.familysearch.org/en/wiki/Puerto_Rico_Civil_Registration

Census Records

The subject of this course. The 1910 federal census captures people born as early as the 1820s, with reported ages that support birth year estimates. The 1887 and 1899 statistical reports provide demographic context for the community, and surviving municipal padrones (Module 5) may provide name-level entries from the Spanish colonial period.

- 1887 Spanish census (statistical report): https://censo.estadisticas.pr/sites/default/files/Decenal/INE_CensodePoblacionyVivienda_1887.pdf
- 1899 military census (statistical report): <https://archive.org/details/reportoncensusof00unit>

Newspapers

Death notices, marriage announcements, legal notices, and community news. The Library of Congress *Chronicling America* collection includes Puerto Rican newspapers in Spanish and English:

<https://chroniclingamerica.loc.gov/>

Notarial, Land, and Probate Records

Notarial protocols (*protocolos notariales*), property records, and estate documents at the Archivo General de Puerto Rico name family members, establish relationships, and place individuals in specific barrios at specific dates:

<https://www.icp.pr.gov/archivo-general/>

Military and Administrative Records

WWI (1917–1918) and WWII (1940–1946) draft registration cards record exact birth dates self-reported by men born as early as the 1870s, and are freely searchable at FamilySearch.

Section 5 — Reconstructing Pre-1885 Facts by Indirect Evidence

Most of the substitutes above provide **indirect evidence** for pre-1885 events: no single record states the fact outright, but several records together support a sound conclusion. Two worked patterns:

Establishing an approximate birth date without a baptismal record. Correlate the reported age in each federal census (1910, 1920, 1930), the age at death in a civil death record, and the exact date on a draft card if one exists. Each source yields an implied birth year. If they converge within a narrow range, state the birth year as approximate, cite every source, and explain the correlation. This is a GPS-compliant conclusion without a parish register.

Establishing parentage without a baptismal record. A civil marriage record names the parents of both spouses. A civil death record usually names the parents of the deceased. The birth records of a person's children name that person and their spouse, confirming the couple's identity across years. Sibling records repeat the parents' names, multiplying the evidence.

In both patterns, write the conclusion as a proof summary: state the claim, list the sources, explain how they correlate, and address any conflicts (Module 8 covers the correlation method in detail).

Section 6 — Documenting Restricted Access and Negative Searches

Under the Genealogical Proof Standard, reasonably exhaustive research includes documenting the records you could not search and why. Restricted access is itself a research finding.

In your research log, record:

- The parish and diocese, the record type, and the date range you needed
- The access status (restricted, not digitized, fragment only) and the date you confirmed it
- The source of that status information (diocesan policy, FamilySearch catalog, archive correspondence)
- The alternative searches you ran instead, with results, including negative results

A documented restriction protects your conclusions. A future reader of your proof argument can see that the parish register was not skipped; it was unavailable, and the conclusion rests on the best evidence that survives. It also leaves a clear re-entry point if access policies change: registers that exist but are restricted today may become available in the future.

Section 7 — Research Strategy Summary

1. **Identify exactly which register you need** — parish, record type, and date range
 2. **Check FamilySearch first** — confirm whether the register was digitized before the restriction
 3. **Log the access status** — record what is available, what is restricted, and when you checked
 4. **Run the alternative strategy** — civil registration, census, newspapers, notarial and land records, draft cards
 5. **Correlate indirect evidence** — build birth dates and parentage from converging sources
 6. **Document every negative search** — absence of a record is evidence of the surviving record base
 7. **Write the conclusion as a proof summary** — claim, sources, correlation, conflicts
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Reflection Questions

1. Your ancestor was born in Rincón around 1860, and the baptismal register is inaccessible. List three record types that could establish an approximate birth year, and state what kind of evidence (direct, indirect, or negative) each would provide.
 2. You confirm that FamilySearch digitized baptisms for your parish only through 1855, and your ancestor was born about 1862. How do you record this in your research log, and what do you search next?
 3. A civil death record from 1901 names your ancestor's parents, but the reported age implies a birth year five years different from the 1910 census entry for the same family. Which module of this course gives you the framework for resolving this, and what would your first step be?
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Worksheet Included

- WS_04 — Alternative Source Strategy Planner & Negative Search Log
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What's Next

Module 10 — Using AI for Census Analysis covers what AI tools can and cannot do in census research, practical workflows for extracting and comparing census data, and how to guard against hallucination while staying GPS-compliant.

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